

Smart, Flat, Smooth Induction Cookers are Here to Stay

Back then, the necessity was fire, and hence it was discovered. Today, for sustainability, the necessity is the 'controlled use of fire,' and ways to achieve this have been invented as well. One of these improvisations is the induction cooker—an invention that is modernising the traditional Indian kitchen and, of course, playing its part in assuring us of a relatively sustainable future. Here *Consumer Voice* brings to you lab-tested findings on twelve brands of induction cookers available in the Indian market

All of us today are being advised to consume minimum energy for maximum output and to reserve, if not preserve, our natural resources while also doing our bit for the environment. From efficient vehicles to efficient lights, to efficient electronics and efficient home appliances, we are getting enough choices to choose from. And though not one of the latest entrants in the list, the induction cooker has become an object of much curiosity.

Steadily, induction cookers are dethroning gas stoves from Indian kitchens—in much the same way as gas stoves replaced oil-filled stoves or coal and wood stoves about a couple of decades ago. Gas stoves were bought for being efficient, economical and non-polluting. Today, characteristics of induction cookers are the same, just that these score several times better on all counts than LPG gas stoves and are also a safer alternative.

The demand for induction cookers is increasing, specifically among the urban households who have limited time and space for cooking, and are certainly not helped by the shortage of LPG supply. So a comparative testing of induction cookers was undertaken by team *Consumer Voice*. Since there are no relevant Indian/international standards readily available, selection of test parameters was a big challenge.



Based on in-house experience as well as recommended cooking selections/options given in the operating manuals of induction cookers, test parameters were finalised. These parameters could be easily validated and justified, and helped the testing team in selecting the best overall performer.

Apart from the test and expert observations, the testing team also identified regular users of induction cookers and took their experience into consideration. For instance, to find out the frying capacity as well as durability aspects, the team spoke to *pakoda* and *samosa* vendors at railway stations who used induction cookers for about 20

hours of frying on a daily basis.

Design and function

In an induction cooker, a coil (spiral) of copper wire is mounted underneath the cooking surface plate where the pot or the vessel is placed. An alternating electric current flows through the coil, producing an oscillating magnetic field. This magnetic field induces an electric current in the vessel. The current flowing in the metal pot or vessel, through the surface plate, produces resistive heating that heats the food in it with minimal heat loss.

While other cooking methods use flames or red-hot heating elements